



YOU ARE **29 WEEKS AND 6 DAYS**

71 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Increasingly sounds enter the uterus and your baby will respond to some of the loudest. The fluid all around them can have quite an effect on the sounds that they can hear—the effect is similar to how you might feel when you swim with your head under water.

“Your maximum blood volume won’t be reached for a few weeks yet, but your circulation is working harder than ever at this stage.”

Your blood volume is likely to be nearly a gallon and a half between weeks 25 and 35—an increase of about 25 percent. This increased blood volume means that your heart is pumping harder and faster. Your blood vessels are as relaxed as they can be by this stage of pregnancy, and will not stretch any further to accommodate this extra blood flow. You may notice that you sweat more, and that your skin feels hotter (this gives a rosy glow to some women). In addition to this extra blood, there is also a lot more fluid circulating around your body, which can cause you to feel swollen.

It’s common and normal for your face, fingers, and ankles to be puffy or swollen (see [Swollen feet, ankles, hands, and wrists](#)). However, since puffiness is also a sign of [preeclampsia](#), it’s important to have your doctor to check this out.

ASK A DOCTOR

I’ve noticed that I get short of breath very easily. Should I be concerned? No, when you’re pregnant, your lungs have to work much harder to meet your body’s increased oxygen needs. To help you take in more air, your ribs spread sideways and your lung capacity increases dramatically. This can make you feel short of breath, particularly from midpregnancy.

In the third trimester, most women find they get breathless even during mild exertion, which happens as the expanding uterus pushes up against the lungs. However, being breathless can also be a sign of [anemia](#), which may need to be treated. Your breathing may start to get easier [when your baby engages](#) (moves down into your pelvis ready to be born).

FOCUS ON TWINS

If you’re pregnant with twins, it’s recommended that you don’t do any vigorous or aerobic exercise in the third trimester. The last three months are particularly tiring so you probably won’t feel up to doing much anyway. You’ll also get bigger sooner than someone who is having a single baby, and your size may preclude you from doing certain activities.